

Signing of Treaty of Paris

George Washington (1732–1799) became the first president of the United States of America. One of the founding fathers of America, he played a significant role in the American Revolution first as a military officer and later as an astute politician.

Important Provisions of the Treaty

- Britain recognised the freedom of 13 colonies and the formation of a new country called the United States of America.
- The area bordered by Mississippi River on the west and the 31st parallel in the south went to USA.
- France gained certain British territories in West Indies, India and Africa.
- Spain obtained Florida from Great Britain
- Holland and England maintained the status quo that prevailed before the war.

Significance of American Revolution

- The American Revolution opened up many avenues in the history of the world.
- The concepts of democracy and republic became widespread.
- The political and social changes were on the lines of democracy and equality.
- USA became a land of opportunities and freedom for all settlers.
- Education gained prominence.
- The principle of federalism became widespread.
- The American Revolution was a setback for colonialism. The demand of the colonies for independence against their colonial masters became widespread in many parts of the world.
- It paved the way for a free society where every individual was given the freedom of speech, freedom of religion and equal opportunities.

11.2 The French Revolution

In the 18th century, Europe was ruled by monarchs of various dynasties, and they wielded absolute powers. Along with the nobility and clergy they enjoyed hereditary privileges. In France the clergy and nobility did not pay taxes like the common people. It was in this context that the French Revolution occurred and stood for liberty, equality, and fraternity.

France in Eighteenth Century



Louis XVI and Marie Antoinette

The political and social system of France prior to the French Revolution was called *ancien regime*, meaning old order. Under the regime, everyone was a member of an estate. All rights and status flowed from three orders namely clergy, nobility and others, belonging to the Third Estate. France was ruled by Louis XVI, a young king of the Bourbon dynasty. He was married to Mary Antoinette, the princess of Austria. The king had absolute power and he led a lavish lifestyle. The government taxed the poor and not the rich.

On 14 July 1789, the Paris mob, hungry due to a lack of food from poor harvests, upset at the conditions of their lives and annoyed with their king and government, stormed the Bastille fortress (a prison). The storming of the Bastille symbolised the beginning of a new age in the history of the world. There were many reasons for the outbreak of this revolution.

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